

Post-Operative Care Guidelines: Total Knee Replacement

Fictional sample document for testing purposes only. Not real medical advice.

Overview

This guideline outlines standard post-operative care recommendations for patients recovering from total knee replacement surgery (also known as total knee arthroplasty). It is intended for use by nursing staff and physical therapists during the first six weeks of recovery.

Pain Management

Patients typically receive a combination of oral analgesics and ice therapy during the first 72 hours. Pain should be reassessed every four hours using a standard 0-10 pain scale. Escalating pain accompanied by swelling or warmth at the incision site should be reported to the attending physician immediately, as this may indicate infection or deep vein thrombosis.

Mobility and Physical Therapy

Weight-bearing as tolerated is generally encouraged starting on the first post-operative day. A physical therapist should evaluate range of motion daily for the first week. Most patients achieve 90 degrees of knee flexion within two weeks and should be walking with a cane or no assistive device by six weeks, depending on baseline fitness and adherence to the exercise program.

Wound Care

The surgical dressing should remain dry and intact for the first 48 hours. Sutures or staples are typically removed between day 10 and day 14. Patients should be instructed to watch for redness, discharge, or fever, all of which warrant a follow-up visit.

Follow-Up Schedule

A follow-up appointment is recommended at two weeks, six weeks, and three months post-surgery to assess healing, range of motion, and overall functional recovery.